

GETTING IT RIGHT



BRAND ACTIVISM

Brand activism is a “high-stakes” strategy where companies take public stands on social or political issues to build goodwill. Done right, it brings rewards. Gone wrong, it causes reputational as well as financial loss



BRAND PERSONALITY & CAUSE

In order to come across as authentic, brands must pick causes that align their personality traits



POLARISED SOCIETY=POLARISED CONSUMER

The world is polarised across issues. People, AKA consumers, are hypersensitive and quick to take offence on developments that seem innocuous on the face of it



CULTURE VS IMAGE

The perilous intersection of contemporary corporate mandates and employee identity is as risky as external brand communication. The Lenskart and TCS controversies are a case in point



CONTEXTUAL EMPATHY

Building a robust modern brand now requires more than just good marketing; it demands strong leadership built on ethics and integrity. Alongside a sound governance framework, brands also need contextual empathy

group, and sells software services to vast domestic and overseas clients.

The TCS case, which has led to the arrest of some employees, involves alleged sexual harassment and forced religious conversion of female staff, and is being probed by the police.

Controversies, especially those pertaining to religious identity, can be perilous. These cast a shadow over the very ethos of the brand besides hurting the sentiments of employees, who are as crucial a stakeholder in a brand's life as consumers are.

MODERN MANDATES

“The Lenskart and TCS Nashik incidents serve as a vital masterclass in how modern corporate mandates can collide with cultural and religious sensitivities,” says Sandeep Goyal, chairman of Rediffusion, one of the country's oldest and largest full-service advertising and communication agencies.

The modern-day corporate mandates Goyal is referring to include practices such as a diverse workforce, equal opportunities, a transparent work culture and good governance, among others.

These are also factors integral to building a robust brand. Ajimon Francis, Managing Director of Brand Finance India, a brand valuation and strategy consultant, points out that for decades, the best brands have been those that not only ran successful marketing and branding campaigns but also demonstrated strong leadership built on ethics, integrity and governance.

The Lenskart and TCS controversies were by no means isolated incidents. As far back as in May 2023, US supermarket chain Target faced large scale calls for boycotts from anti-LGBTQ (Lesbian, Gay, Bisexual, Transgender, Queer) groups after it released its Pride Month merchandise amid allegations that “tuck-friendly” products were being sold to children.

Target saw a decline in its online as well as offline revenues and lost nearly \$10 billion in market cap within a few days of the controversy erupting.

Back home, Fabindia, which sells traditional products handcrafted by rural artisans, triggered a controversy with the launch of its *Jashn-e-Riwaaz* festive collection ahead of Diwali in 2021.

The Urdu tagline was intended to convey the idea of communal harmony in the celebration of festivals.

A year earlier, Tanishq found itself at the centre of a controversy around an advertisement for its newly launched *Ekatvam* (oneness) jewellery line